

Site Architecture and Crawl Depth

Architecture is where your authority flows. Bury a page and you have decided it does not matter.

Bottom line

Every commercial page should be reachable within three clicks of the homepage. Pages five or more clicks deep are crawled less often and receive less link equity. Architecture is not a diagram exercise, it is the mechanism that decides which of your pages can compete.

What architecture actually does

It distributes authority. Your homepage typically holds the most, mostly from external links. Every link from it passes some on. Pages far from the homepage receive very little.

It signals importance. Click depth is a statement. A page linked from the homepage is important; a page six clicks down is not, and Google reads it that way.

It determines crawl frequency. Deep pages are crawled less often, so updates take longer to register.

It groups topics. From Section 15, a coherent structure makes topical relationships explicit rather than leaving them to be inferred.

The rules

Rule	Value	Tier
Clicks from homepage to any commercial page	3 maximum	[practitioner]
Depth at which pages start being neglected	5+ clicks	[practitioner]
Category depth	3 levels maximum	[practitioner]

Click depth means the shortest path following links, not URL folder depth. A page at /a/b/c/d/e/page linked from the homepage is one click deep.

The shape

Flat enough to reach, structured enough to mean something.

`` Homepage ■■■■ Services ■ ■■■■ SEO ■ ■■■■ Web Development ■ ■■■■ AI Automation ■■■■ Industries ■ ■■■■ SaaS ■ ■■■■ Ecommerce ■■■■ Resources (pillar pages) ■ ■■■■ SEO Guide (pillar) ■ ■ ■■■■ cluster page ■ ■ ■■■■ cluster page ■ ■■■■ Automation Guide (pillar) ■■■■ About / Contact ``

Everything commercial sits two clicks from home. Cluster pages sit three, which is acceptable because the pillar concentrates authority and passes it down.

Do not go completely flat. Linking every page from the homepage removes hierarchy entirely, dilutes the nav, and tells Google nothing about relationships.

The three mechanisms that control depth

Navigation. The strongest and bluntest. Everything in the main nav is linked from every page. From Section 13, keep it to about seven items, because a fifteen-item nav concentrates nothing.

Contextual internal links. From Section 16. This is how you pull an important deep page up without cluttering the nav.

Breadcrumbs. Reinforce hierarchy, help users, and with BreadcrumbList schema make the structure machine-readable independently of prose. Described as one of the most under-implemented signals available. [practitioner]

Category and hub pages

Category pages that are only a list of links are thin by default and rarely rank.

Give each one:

- A genuine introduction explaining what the category covers and who it is for
- Context around the links rather than a bare grid
- Its own target cluster from your Section 8 map

A category page done properly is a pillar page. Done lazily it is a crawl waypoint that ranks for nothing.

Faceted navigation

The largest architectural problem on ecommerce and directory sites, and the biggest generator of crawl waste.

Colour x size x brand x price x sort order produces thousands or millions of URLs from a few hundred products. Each looks like a page. Almost none deserves indexing.

Handling it:

- **Index the facet combinations people actually search for.** "Blue running shoes" probably has demand. "Blue running shoes size 9 sorted by price ascending" does not.
- **noindex the rest**, with a self-referencing canonical or canonical back to the clean category.
- **Block genuine infinite traps in robots.txt**, remembering from Section 21 to clean up the index first, since a disallowed URL cannot read a noindex.
- **Do not internally link to parameterized URLs** from your own navigation. Most facet explosions are self-inflicted.

Pagination

Keep it simple. `rel=next` and `rel=prev` are no longer used by Google.

- Each paginated page carries a **self-referencing canonical**. Do not canonicalize page 2 to page 1, they are different content.
- Usually `noindex` beyond page 1 for blog and category listings, unless the deeper pages genuinely have search demand.
- **Make sure products or articles on deep pagination are reachable another way**, through categories, tags, or the sitemap. Item 400 on page 20 is effectively unreachable otherwise.

Finding depth problems

Crawl the site and sort by crawl depth. Screaming Frog reports it directly. Anything important at depth 4 or more needs a shorter path.

Check that path. Click from the homepage to your most important service page, counting. Most people are surprised.

Look for orphans. From Section 16, zero internal links means effectively invisible.

Compare depth against value. If your highest-margin service is at depth 4 and a 2019 blog post is at depth 1, your architecture disagrees with your business.

Why this matters

architecture decisions are usually made once, early, by whoever built the site, for reasons that had nothing to do with search. They then quietly determine which pages can compete for the next five years. It is one of the few areas where a couple of hours of restructuring can lift a whole section of a site.

Do this now

- 1 Draw your current architecture.** Actually draw it. Homepage, main sections, what sits under each.
- 2 Click from the homepage to your three most important commercial pages**, counting clicks. Write the numbers down.
- 3 Crawl the site and sort by depth.** List anything important at depth 4 or more.
- 4 For each, decide the mechanism** to pull it up: nav, contextual links, or a hub page.
- 5 Audit your category pages.** Any that are just link lists get a real introduction.
- 6 Count your main nav items.** Over about seven, cut.
- 7 Check breadcrumbs exist** on deep pages, and note whether they have BreadcrumbList schema. Section 30 implements it.
- 8 If you have faceted navigation**, check `site:yourdomain.com inurl:?` and see how many parameter URLs are indexed.
- 9 Fix the single worst depth problem** you found.

Capstone step

You have a drawn architecture, measured click depth to your key pages, a plan for anything buried too deep, category pages that are more than link lists, and one real depth problem fixed.

Key takeaways

- Three clicks maximum from the homepage to any commercial page. Five or more and the page is crawled less and receives less authority.
- Click depth is shortest link path, not URL folder depth.
- Category pages that are only link lists are thin. Given a real introduction and a target cluster, a category page is a pillar page.
- Faceted navigation is the biggest crawl-waste generator, and most facet explosions are caused by a site linking to its own parameterized URLs.